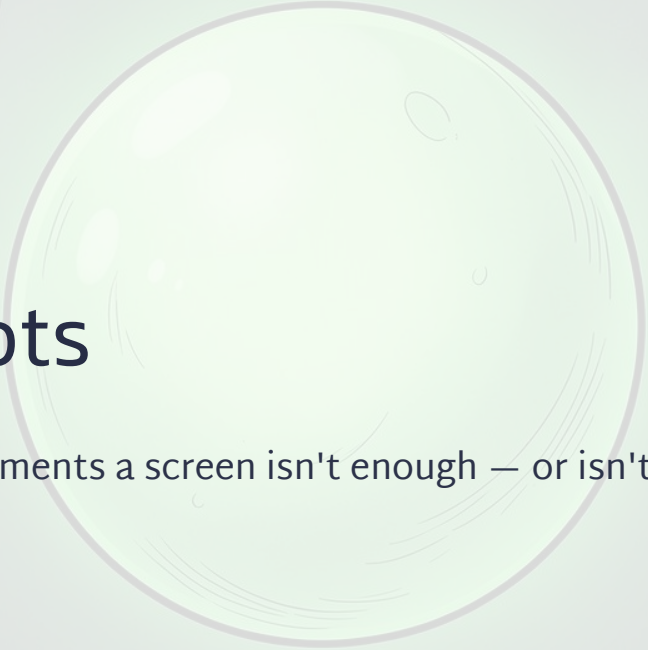




A STEADY BONUS

Panic Button Scripts

Word-for-word, offline backup for the moments a screen isn't enough — or isn't there.

How to use this

These aren't things to read and understand later — they're things to say to yourself, out loud or in your head, while it's happening. You don't need to remember them. Print this, screenshot it, keep it in your bag. When your mind is racing, reading is easier than composing.

Find the scenario closest to what's happening, and just start reading. You don't have to believe the words yet. Say them anyway — belief tends to catch up a few lines in.

  **One thing before every script:** If you can, put a hand flat on your chest or your stomach as you read. It's a small thing, but touch gives your nervous system something concrete to register — "I'm here, I'm okay" — while the words do the rest.



My heart is racing and I think something's wrong

WHEN: CHEST TIGHTNESS, POUNDING HEART, DIZZINESS, SUDDEN DREAD

"This is panic, not danger. My heart races because my body is doing exactly what it's built to do when it (wrongly) thinks I'm in danger. That's uncomfortable, not dangerous.

Panic peaks and then it drops. It always does. It has every single time before. I don't have to make it stop — I just have to wait it out.

I'm going to breathe out longer than I breathe in. In for four. Out for six. Again. In for four. Out for six.

My body will catch up to what I already know: I'm safe right now."

Follow-up: Open Steady and run Box Breathing or 4-7-8 as soon as you can — this script buys you the first sixty seconds until you get there.

I'm panicking in public and I need it to not be visible

WHEN: AT WORK, ON A TRAIN, IN A MEETING, MID-CONVERSATION

"Nobody around me can see what's happening inside my chest right now. What they can see is someone sitting quietly. That's all I need to do — sit quietly.

I don't need to leave the room. I don't need to explain anything to anyone. I just need to get through the next two minutes.

Feet flat on the floor. Notice that. Hands in my lap, or around this cup, or on this table. Notice that.

I am going to pick three things I can see without turning my head, and name them silently. One. Two. Three.

This will pass before anyone notices it happened at all."

Follow-up: This is the 5-4-3-2-1 grounding technique, shortened. The full version is in Steady if you get a moment alone afterward.

My thoughts are spiraling and I can't stop them

WHEN: ONE WORRY LEADS TO ANOTHER LEADS TO ANOTHER, AND IT WON'T STOP CHAINING

"My mind is doing the thing where one worry drags in the next one. That's the spiral, not the truth. The tenth thought isn't more true than the first one — it's just further from it.

I'm going to stop trying to think my way out, because that's what's feeding it. Instead I'm going to answer one question: what is actually happening right now, in this room, in this minute?

[Answer it. Out loud if you can.]

Everything else is my mind rehearsing things that haven't happened. I can think about it later, on paper, when I'm not mid-spiral. Right now I only owe my attention to this minute."

Follow-up: When you can, open Steady's Journal and do a full brain dump, or the Thought Reframe tool if one specific thought keeps returning.



I have to walk into something big and I'm frozen

WHEN: BEFORE AN INTERVIEW, EXAM, PRESENTATION, DIFFICULT CONVERSATION

"This feeling is my body getting ready, not my body warning me to run. Same chemicals as excitement. I'm going to borrow that word for the next ten minutes: excited, not terrified.

I am prepared enough. Not perfectly — enough. Enough is what actually walks through doors.

If it goes badly, I will still be a whole person five minutes after it's over. This is one hour of my life, not the rest of it.

Shoulders down. One breath in through the nose. Long breath out. I'm going to walk in now, while the breath is still going out."

Follow-up: A 2-minute Coherent Breathing session in Steady beforehand keeps your heart rate from spiking as you walk in.

I woke up anxious at 3am for no reason

WHEN: SUDDEN WAKING, RACING HEART, MIND IMMEDIATELY ON ALERT IN THE DARK

"It's the middle of the night. Nothing has actually changed since I fell asleep — my mind just has nothing to distract it right now, so it's reaching for something to worry about.

I don't have to solve anything at 3am. Nothing gets better-solved right now than it will at a normal hour. I'm allowed to close this thought and open it again tomorrow.

I'm going to keep my eyes closed and slow my exhale down — longer out than in — and let my body believe it's still resting, even if my mind isn't fully convinced yet.

If I'm still awake in twenty minutes, I'll get up, sit somewhere dim, and come back to this page instead of lying here fighting it."

Follow-up: See the "Sleep Without the Spiral" checklist for the fuller version of this.

Someone just told me to "relax" or "calm down"

WHEN: WELL-MEANING ADVICE MAKES IT WORSE, NOT BETTER

"They mean well, even if that landed badly. Nobody can just switch this off, and it's not a character flaw that I can't either.

I don't owe anyone an explanation of what this feels like from inside. I just owe myself the next sixty seconds of actually taking care of it, quietly, my own way.

I'm allowed to say 'I need a minute' and step away. That's not rude — that's the most useful thing I can do for both of us right now."

One last thing

If panic is showing up like this often — several times a week, or badly enough that it's shrinking what you're willing to do — these scripts are a genuinely useful in-the-moment tool, but they're not a ceiling. A therapist can help you work on why it's happening this often, not just how to get through it when it does.



If you ever feel unsafe with yourself, not just anxious, please reach out to a crisis line or emergency services in your area right away. That's not what these scripts are for, and no script should be asked to carry that alone.